was deeply comforted after connecting with Rakesh, for if I had not, it would have haunted my mind all through the trip.

My mind automatically switched off from all this as I boarded the plane for Frankfurt on my way to Rio de Janeiro.

Appointment as Governor

As my plane landed in Delhi in the early morning of 2 September, my phone started beeping incessantly with an unusual flood of messages. I was confused about the congratulations since not one of them contained any clue. I called Urmila who gave me the news of my appointment as governor and did not miss out on complaining that the previous evening she had done nothing but field phone calls from literally hundreds of people, many of them not even known to us.

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I would be the twenty-second governor of the Reserve Bank in its seventy-three-year history—the eleventh bureaucrat to don the governor's mantle. Finance secretaries had become governors in the past too, but I would be the first finance sectary to go directly from the North Block to Mint Street without a gap in between. I would also be the first governor of the Reserve Bank born after Independence.

The news was expectedly all over the TV and print media over the next couple of days, instantly turning me from an unknown unknown to a known unknown. There was coverage of my background and career trajectory, and also extensive commentary on my reform credentials and policy biases.

In over one year as finance secretary, I had occasion to make a few statements on inflation, financial sector reforms and capital-account liberalization. At the time I made these comments, they passed off as relatively innocuous items, but now analysts, columnists and economic journalists were digging them up to evaluate my potential policy stance as the prospective governor.